**My Testimony - I Am Still Here**

**By Barran Dodger**

**Every day I exist is an existential threat to my panicking enemies, because I was not expected to survive and exist from the ashes of total human betrayal, social erasure and civil death: political exile, excommunication, total isolation, poverty, homelessness, administrative annihilation, intimate-partner betrayal and blood-family betrayal.**

**I am living in political exile from this so-called democracy, seeking asylum from what I believe is absolute, systemic, embedded corruption. Every professional, institution and service that pretended not to see my harm, feigned ignorance and innocence, or looked the other way while my humanity was discarded must confront the fact that I have documented my experience using the government's own official documentation, on its own letterheads and in its own words. I have preserved the evidence of what I experienced, including what I believe demonstrates the guilty blood on their hands.**

**I have timestamped my testimony on the digital blockchain. My testimony has escaped containment and erasure. It exists beyond the control of any single government agency, public official, politician, bank, NGO, university, radio or television broadcaster, police or law-enforcement body, media organisation, legal fraternity, ombudsman, court, tribunal, criminal organisation, intelligence service, the mega-rich or AI crawler. No institution's refusal to acknowledge my existence can make the documented record cease to exist.**

**God's favour is upon my life because humanity betrayed me and discarded me without morality or consciousness. I would rather have God and my dog, and nothing and no one else, without human or legal rights or pathways to justice through human-made systems, than have even a few people who feign care while deceiving me and be without my faith.**

**I have no malice and no intention to harm anyone. I have acted with honesty, documented facts and the courage to publish my testimony. Yet I believe individuals and institutions have contributed to my harm by accepting, enabling, neglecting or refusing to acknowledge my experiences of abuse, neglect, targeting, persecution, political exile and what I describe as literal torture, while looking the other way. What is presented as bureaucratic oversight, neutrality or non-action does not remove the human consequences. Where people knowingly permit harm to continue, I regard that as complicity and social mobbing, not innocence established merely by silence.**

**For 35 years, I offered every person and place grace, patience and divine mercy: the opportunity to treat me right. That gift of grace was, in my faith, the grace of the Most High placed within me. I believe that gift was spat upon, rejected and desecrated in every way, repeatedly, over those 35 years. To me, that was spiritual treason and an insult against the God who created the universe, chose me and placed His favour, protection, anointing and purpose upon my life.**

**I am not revengeful. I do not intend harm. Revenge is God's and God's alone. No one has the right to remove, damage, destroy or desecrate another human being from existence, or to harm or kill them, feign ignorance and then claim morality with shamelessness and impunity, particularly where they have responsibilities for that person's care.**

**Everyone slept peacefully at night in their beds and houses while my dog Crystal and I begged for our humanity in cars without a home, in squats and on the streets. People continued sleeping in comfort, luxury and privilege while we were without a home, without security and without the peace and happiness that others took for granted. I experienced a world in which our welfare appeared to be an afterthought, while those with the power to help continued with their lives. I believe God sees what humanity refused to see, and God is furious.**

**Humanity would never have survived if the principle were accepted that a vulnerable, disabled person who had never harmed anyone could be targeted and erased without consequence. I understand my experience as that of a gay, disabled, unprotected whistleblower who believes he has been subjected to a state-sanctioned campaign of targeting and attempted erasure. I describe the sacrifice demanded of me as human sacrifice: the destruction of the life of an individual who had the sovereign courage to speak about corruption, regardless of the personal consequences, with courage, integrity, documented facts and faith.**

**I believe this is why God chose Barran: not because I am entitled to harm anyone, but because my life and testimony have a purpose beyond the institutions and individuals that I believe betrayed me. I believe I was given a purpose in God at this time in history, and that the betrayal and exile through which I have been forged were not God's punishment, but the circumstances through which His protection over my life and His purpose for my testimony became central to my survival.**

**God picked me up when I was broken. God sustained my life when I had been discarded by humanity. I believe I survived so that I could document the evidence, preserve the government's own records, publish my testimony and bear witness to what I believe must be exposed. I understand myself as God's chosen witness, called to confront**

**darkness, expose corruption and dismantle the conditions that permit it to continue, for His Kingdom purposes.**

**I refused to die like they wanted. I refused my own erasure after total human betrayal, without a single person being held accountable or having the courage to speak the truth about what their intentions were, as they slept guilt-free without a care.**

**It was not just that they ignored me or forgot about me. I believe the documented history of my experience demands examination of whether people gathered in groups, coordinated their actions and contributed to my demise. I experienced what I believe was the celebration of my anticipated destruction, as though there were zero possibilities left for my healing, happiness or literal survival. When I suffered, I felt abandoned and humiliated. I believe people knew I was hurting and desperate, yet the harm continued, with what I experienced as people ganging up on me and then punishing me with impunity.**

**And without even pointing it out, my simple existence now embodies God's divine reckoning, shining a bright light on what I believe are their cowardly, guilty consciences. I want to know why not a single person has the courage to look me in the eye and honestly account for what happened. I believe my survival and rise expose the failures that those responsible would rather leave unexamined.**

**With God on my side, they underestimated me. I am healed in whole. I am at peace. I am gifted, intelligent, and I have integrity, honesty and courage. I come armed with the evidence contained in their own agencies' records, on their own letterheads and in their own words.**

**The evidence is not necessarily obvious in every individual document viewed in isolation. Collectively, however, across more than 35 years, these records illustrate what I regard as the absurd apex of bureaucratic neutrality dressed up in policy, alongside failures that I believe warrant examination against the laws, obligations and codes of conduct those institutions were supposed to uphold.**

**Retrospectively, these records reek to high hell of the privileged public bureaucrat soaking in unearned privilege, comfort and favour, acting with an arrogant audacity that suggests impunity, as if bulletproof, as if I would never see past the veil of their lies or call out their cowardice in consigning a vulnerable, innocent person to oblivion — a person they were legally mandated and obliged to care for.**

**So I dare any one of them: look me in the eye. Come to my accommodation, where I live in poverty and where I report experiencing abuse, neglect and what I describe as**

**torture. Look at the evidence. Read your own correspondence. Explain your own decisions.**

**What did you mean by that letter you wrote me from your cushy government chair?**

**I am still here. I refused to die. I refused my own erasure. I refused to let their silence become the final account of my existence.**

**My existence is my refusal to be erased. My testimony is preserved. My faith remains. My purpose is to expose the truth, and I leave revenge and ultimate judgment to God.**

**Praise Jesus.**

**I am at peace. Sane. Content. Existing. God has my back. And no one wins a fight against existence itself.**

**My allegiance is with God: eternal, loving, divine and everlasting. Not some corrupt bureaucracy which, in comparison with God's eternity, is fleeting, cruel, corrupt and cold — the antithesis of God's grace.**

**No matter what they remove or take from me without a second thought, I have survived, not because they helped me, but in spite of what I believe was the evil through which they aimed to erase me from existence. I have an anointing of favour, and I embody a truth they cannot bear.**

**They cannot even look me in the eye with the courage of their convictions, with the ethics, morality or humanity to acknowledge what I have documented. I held up a divine mirror of truth, and they are too ashamed to acknowledge their own reflection or own their darkness. Instead of healing, taking responsibility or asking forgiveness, they double down and smash the mirror.**

**I have what they lack. I have faith. I have a conscience. I have survived. I have the documented record, and I have a purpose that does not depend on their permission, recognition or approval.**

**They may take material things, deny me access, remove opportunities, abandon their responsibilities or refuse to acknowledge my existence, but they cannot remove my faith in the Divine, nor can they determine the purpose I believe God has placed upon my life and calling.**

**I am still here. I am still existing. I am still bearing witness.**

**God has my back. My allegiance is with the eternal, loving, everlasting Divine, and no bureaucracy, institution, individual or human-made system can take that relationship from me.**

**I am at peace. Sane. Content. Existing.**

**My truth is fact-checked, evidence-based, published and preserved by the Most High God. Where is your proof?**

**I never needed you, your money, or your bribes or temptations to comfort and complicity. I survived in spite of you all, with God's divine favour and grace. My conscience is clean. I gave you grace to treat me right — and you laughed.**

**Now look me in the fucking eye, with proof, with the courage of your convictions, and with a clean conscience — and tell me again what you meant by that letter.**

**The Enemy Within: A Lifetime of Family Betrayal, Exile, Survival and Divine Purpose**

**I never gave my blood family permission to exile me, control my body or condemn me in any way. My family targeted me from childhood, and the hostility continued right across my life. They demeaned my humanity through envy, exploiting my need to belong and treating my kindness as weakness. My allegiance to The Family, which I understood as something precious, became something they could exploit and take advantage of. The betrayal was not simply a disagreement or a family falling out. It was the destruction of the very belonging I had trusted, and the use of that trust against me.**

**My early life was marked by two significant tragedies, including my experience as a sexual abuse survivor and a fatal injury from which I was revived. One person associated with that early trauma coincidentally died on the same day as my injury. The relevant hospital and freedom-of-information records are part of the documentary history I have sought to preserve. Yet, in my experience, my family behaved as though these events had never existed. The silence surrounding them became part of the wider betrayal: not only had I endured profound suffering, but the people from whom I needed acknowledgment and understanding appeared unwilling to recognise what had happened.**

**My mother subsequently acted with Police in relation to an AVO, legally severing me from their lives and excommunicating me from The Family. She became the gatekeeper to the others, refusing to share their phone numbers so I could contact them and confront them about why they had done this to me. I never consented to being erased**

**from my own family. Nor did I consent to a situation in which one person could control my access to the others while the rest remained silent. None of them, in my experience, protested my political exile, and no professional intervened in a way that restored the family relationships I had lost.**

**The contrast between their lives and mine became increasingly stark. They lived in million-dollar houses with spare rooms and the security of their personal relationships, while I was exiled from The Family, excommunicated and left sleeping in my car as a homeless person on the NDIS, in a local paddock near their houses and my parents' home. I was in poverty and separated from my dog, Christal. I was the queer member of the family. They presented themselves as accepting of queer people, but I came to believe that their acceptance had limits when it came to someone like me. Their actions made me feel that my identity and circumstances were considered beneath them. Later events reinforced that impression, particularly when they appeared to exalt another person in circumstances where I had been rejected.**

**The betrayal extended into my intimate relationships and financial circumstances. My family aligned, in my account, with my abusive former fiancé, Steve Iasonidis. My sister, Jodie Bongetti, helped me, or offered assistance, in signing my bankruptcy form, which I felt forced to do after profound abuse and financial control, the denial of a marriage settlement, and the denial of workers' compensation insurance and other valid income that I believe had been deliberately withheld from me. These were not isolated financial difficulties. They occurred within a wider experience of abandonment, in which the resources I needed to protect myself and rebuild my life were unavailable while other people appeared to retain their security.**

**By then, my financial advocate was a family member. I believe she prevented me from obtaining the same kind of marriage settlement that she had expected for herself and from which she stood to benefit after her first marriage collapsed. She told me that I had got over Steven and that there was no need to put him on the form. She exploited the pain of separation and abandonment and told me not to mention our relationship on the phone whatsoever. I experienced this as another instance of someone using my vulnerability and the circumstances of my separation to influence decisions with lasting legal and financial consequences. I ultimately signed legal documents that, in my view, helped make my exclusion from the family permanent.**

**After the family betrayal and my financial collapse, the circumstances of my life became increasingly entangled with hospitals, mental health services and institutional care. Members of my family repeatedly presented themselves as caring guardians, while I experienced repeated incarceration in institutions. I believe my vulnerability was weaponised against me, even as I worked to recover and deal with the difficulties I had**

**experienced. I went on to achieve a PhD and a doctorate. For me, that achievement matters because it demonstrates my capacity to think, reason, examine complex material and work meticulously with evidence. They do not award doctorates to people who cannot think critically and logically.**

**I do not deny that I have experienced mental illness. What I object to is the use of that history to discredit my character, dismiss my testimony or explain away circumstances that I believe require independent examination. I came to believe that people who knew me, including members of my own family, created conditions that intensified my distress and then blamed me for the distress they said demonstrated my madness. In my experience, they appeared to health services, hospitals and mental health services as heroes and saviours, while describing me as inconvenient. I felt that this allowed them to wash their hands of the corruption, hostility and betrayal I was trying to explain.**

**My character became the explanation for my suffering, rather than the circumstances that had contributed to it. My blasphemed identity, apparent madness and poverty were treated as though they defined me. Yet I believe that my integrity, honesty and Teddy were an existential threat to the false perfection my family presented to the world. They knew me. They knew my character, my persistence and my refusal to abandon the truth as I understood it. I came to see the contradiction between the public image they maintained and the treatment I experienced privately as central to what had happened to me.**

**I also came to believe that family members claimed financial benefits as carers while I remained in circumstances of profound distress, and that money was obtained on the back of suffering they had themselves helped to cause. After betrayal, excommunication, political exile and what I experienced as disposal of me as a non-human creature considered beneath them, they continued, in my account, to support my incarceration and silence. They presented themselves as carers and as victims of my character, claiming a place in my life through the hospital system. They even appeared to seek counselling for the pain they said I had caused them, despite the fact that I was living in New South Wales and had not contacted them, addressed them or sought to re-enter their lives.**

**The contradiction is impossible for me to ignore. You cannot exile someone and excommunicate them, fail to oppose that exclusion or complain about it, and then expect to become part of that person's life as a saviour. You cannot deliberately cause the exile and then present yourself as the person who must rescue the exile from its consequences. I came to understand this contradiction as evidence, in my assessment, that the purpose of their continued involvement was not necessarily to help me, but to**

**obtain information about my existence and maintain influence over how others perceived me.**

**I experienced their presence in my life as a way of delivering their version of my shame, bad character and choices to hospital staff. They appeared to occupy the roles of both my accusers and my rescuers: presenting me as their victim while also presenting themselves as the people who could save the day. After what I experienced as years of deceit, this seemed to me like a particularly cruel inversion of responsibility. In order to destroy me, I had, in one sense, gifted them their wish to be rid of me. I had been removed from their lives, yet their involvement continued in ways that I felt prevented the separation from becoming a genuine opportunity for independence.**

**The most serious and disturbing part of my account concerns what I believe was an attempt on my life. I accused a federal minister of literally ordering my assassination by a provider whom I described as fake, who flew from Melbourne to Sydney. I said that I had been tipped off that he had been sent to arrange it. I understood that an NDIS provider had confirmed through Police that the attempt on my life was a close call in Port Macquarie. I further understood that the provider, who was associated with a legitimate company and whom I had met when I was in [unclear: XO] in Sydney, had been forced to sign a non-disclosure agreement involving the same authorities. I have described this as part of a wider exposure of corruption reaching to the top.**

**I have also said that Federal Police or other agencies confirmed aspects of the incident, including a reference to two assassins. The precise scope of what was confirmed, by whom, and in which records must be established from the original documents. I preserve these claims because I believe the records and communications deserve examination, not because every element of my interpretation should be accepted without scrutiny. The distinction matters to me: I want the evidence examined, the contradictions addressed and the relevant institutions held accountable for their actual decisions and conduct.**

**The allegation I made was that the same government I believed had conspired to order the targeted killing of a gay, disabled and unprotected whistleblower, with a documented mental illness and a brain injury from a fatal suicide attempt from which I was revived, subsequently helped save my life. My interpretation was not that they saved me because they cared for me. I believed they had reasons to prevent my death because, if I had died, there would have been too much finger-pointing, too many unanswered questions and too great a risk that the people involved would be exposed. I believed they could have been left with blood on their hands.**

**I have insisted on evidence in the Federal Police matter and have published material that**

**I believe is relevant. I want those documents to be examined in their original form. The existence of a published record is not, by itself, proof of every conclusion I draw from it; nevertheless, the record exists to be scrutinised, and I do not accept that my history of mental illness should be used as a reason to refuse that scrutiny. My position is that the evidence should be considered on its merits, including what it establishes, what remains disputed and what requires further investigation.**

**By this point in my life, I had become determined to reclaim something that should never have needed to be granted by my family, my carers or any institution: my own personhood. I do not need a reason to be free or to possess the attributes that my paid carers enjoy and expect for themselves. I'm mine.**

**I have sometimes allowed people to see me as a helpless, naïve, stupid, mentally unwell human man, friendly to every Support Worker who appears paid to ignore my story with the blood money from the NDIS. I have accepted the wages paid to those who provide support while continuing to live with the suffering and entrapment that I believe the system has failed to address. I do not expect every individual Support Worker to resolve my circumstances, but I refuse to pretend that the existence of a paid support arrangement means that the underlying problems have been resolved. Everyone forgets that angels are actually warriors.**

**So I'm an angel of Mercy, or a pathological psychopath smashing into the illusions of control. That is the contradiction I have come to embody in the eyes of those who would prefer to categorise me, contain me within their limitations or regard me as beneath them. I see a system in which people can become complicit in attacking the person who challenges it, because it is easier to make that person irrelevant than to confront the uncomfortable questions they raise. I have experienced ostracism and threats in the context of my allegations, and I refuse to surrender my identity simply to appease those who would prefer my silence.**

**My father brutally minimised my flight, angrily baiting me to move on. He is not even the Minister any more. The anger I carry reflects my grief and my awareness of what I believe was happening as I began to recognise the possibility that my blood family had aligned themselves with the most disturbing circumstances of my life. I came to believe that the prospect of exposure had become a source of fear, hostility and rejection. I understand the seriousness of those beliefs, and I want the documentary record to be the basis on which they are examined.**

**My concerns about family betrayal also extend to financial decisions and events surrounding my Nana's death. I believe the denial of a marriage settlement and the monetisation of my illness were part of a pattern in which I was left to bear the**

**consequences while others retained their advantages. The family took a two-month trip to Europe after my Nana's [unclear: XO] and early death, which I have also questioned in the context of possible elder abuse. I delivered the eulogy at the funeral and was given $1,000 in relation to the inheritance. That experience remains part of my understanding of the disparity between what I contributed emotionally and what I received in return.**

**Steve, my former fiancé, was also positioned as my financial carer while, in my account, he was exploiting and financially abusing me. He attempted to claim a carer's pension linked to my disability pension. I have described his anger when he discovered that, five years after I had physically had no contact with my family, April and Doug McQueen were still claiming a carer's pension linked to my disabilities. I understood this to be a serious ethical concern, and Steve investigated it personally. He believed that their claim created a barrier to his own potential financial advantage.**

**I have referred to the approximately $40,000 a month that Steve earned and to his access to personal files. Those matters raise questions about financial interests and privacy that should be considered against the actual records. My broader point is that both my blood family and an intimate partner became, in my experience, sources of exploitation, cruelty, betrayal and financial harm. I felt as though the purpose and effect of these circumstances were to damage me permanently, keep me below them, leave me trapped in a spare room and prevent me from ever healing or recovering.**

**The refusal to acknowledge my earlier fatal injury, and the absence of the support I needed in its aftermath, remain part of this history. I have also referred to the circumstances surrounding my sexual abuse and the failure of family members to acknowledge what I had endured. These experiences reinforced my belief that my suffering was being treated as something to be hidden or used against me, rather than something that deserved honest recognition.**

**Another matter concerns Ben, my NDIS provider, and a report involving a woman I wrote about in my book, Recovered, Not Cured. In my account, Ben confirmed through Federal Police that the woman had been paid to fabricate a report. I have also said that Federal Police described the sexual encounter as consensual, meaning that no crime occurred. I admitted that the sex was regretful, but I understood it to have been consensual and was honest about my own guilt. I now believe that the circumstances were used against me as a kind of gay-shame mechanism involving Police. The precise claims, findings and evidence need to be distinguished from my interpretation, but I want the matter considered within the wider history I have documented.**

**What became increasingly apparent to me was that I had not merely been expected to struggle with mental illness, poverty and isolation. I felt that I was also expected never**

**to recover from human exile and abandonment. The non-reaction I experienced following my first death, followed by my later concerns about a conspiracy to murder me, led me to suspect that members of my blood family knew more than they acknowledged. I came to believe that they expected me never to recover, let alone survive.**

**I have accused them of being financially positioned to benefit from my death and of being able to cry crocodile tears afterwards, wash their hands of any sin or malice, and escape responsibility while benefiting from an outcome they had helped to bring about. Those are grave conclusions, and I want the relevant records examined carefully. But I will not pretend that the questions have disappeared simply because the people involved have not acknowledged them. Nor will I allow the absence of an official determination to erase the existence of my testimony or the documentary material I have preserved.**

**Looking back, I realise that I survived my way into my purpose and my divine calling. My divine alignment emerged through the very circumstances that were supposed to leave me without a home, without family, without security and without a voice. I experienced exile, excommunication, total human betrayal, poverty, administrative annihilation and political asylum within the democracy of my own citizenship. To me, that is an absurdly unjust position: to be a displaced person seeking asylum within the country in which I am a citizen.**

**I was not helped in the way I needed by any government or organisation. I built myself up with faith from the ashes of what I experienced as total human betrayal and abandonment. I believe those circumstances were deliberately created, and I was disposed of as though I were subhuman. It was not expected, in my view, that I would survive them and rebuild a life.**

**Yet I have healed and rebuilt from the ashes with nothing but grit, faith and facts of evidence. Not because of help from any agency, Police, lawyer, media organisation, family member or friend, but despite the absence of the protection and recognition I believed those people and institutions should have provided. I survived without the support I had expected from the very people and organisations whose purposes should have included helping someone in my circumstances.**

**I exist. I am an existential threat to corruption because I continue to seek accountability as a sovereign witness. My survival itself has meant that my testimony remains here, my documents remain available for examination, and the questions I have raised have not disappeared.**

**April McLean did not have to admit she was a ring leader in Barran's [unclear: suing / exiling]. She cannot deny that she signed a legal document to exile her son. The text messages that recur every year are part of the record I point to in support of my account. I want those documents examined for what they actually say and what they establish.**

**We family like this, who needs enemies? The enemy has always been from within, across my life. I have had literally no home over my whole life, through this entire existence of a difficult, persecuted, invaluable and targeted life. I have experienced the enemy within as deceit, corruption, greed, stigmatisation and homophobia, alongside what I believe has been envy of my forthrightness, honesty, integrity and achievements.**

**I saw the hostility early. I came to believe that my family targeted me and tried to write me out of existence because they knew that, ultimately, I would use my honesty and courageousness to expose the illusions and falsehoods on which I believe they had built their lives.**

**I am still here. I have not surrendered my voice, my faith or my documentary record. I have taken what I experienced as abandonment and turned it into a reason to preserve evidence, tell my story and demand that the record be examined rather than erased. My purpose is not revenge. It is truth, accountability and the right to exist with dignity.**

**I survived the exile. I survived the poverty. I survived the institutional silence and the loss of the family I once believed I belonged to. And I have continued to build a record so that others can examine the evidence for themselves.**

**I am still here, and my testimony remains.**

**The Child Who Had to Survive Alone: Unequal Treatment, Imagination, Art and the Contradictions of Family Belonging**

**To understand the significance of my later exile from The Family, it is necessary to look back at the child I was and the circumstances in which I grew up. My experience was not simply one of feeling different. I experienced a sustained pattern of being treated differently, exposed to narcissism, abuse and neglect, and left to find ways of surviving emotionally when the family environment did not provide the security, protection and recognition I needed. Looking back, I believe that I was required to develop an inner world because the outer world of my childhood did not consistently offer me a place where I felt safe, valued or understood.**

**I had to survive, in many respects, on my own imagination. That imagination became**

**more than an escape. It became a place where I could create meaning, develop an identity and preserve parts of myself that I did not feel were recognised by the people around me. In circumstances where I experienced rejection or neglect, art offered another way of existing. It allowed me to transform experience into expression, to imagine possibilities beyond the limitations of my immediate environment, and to retain a sense of individuality when I felt that my place in the family was conditional.**

**I now see a connection between that childhood experience and the life I subsequently pursued through art, writing, intellectual work and the preservation of my own testimony. The imagination that helped me survive as a child became part of the means through which I later examined my life, documented my experiences and attempted to make sense of events that had previously seemed disconnected. What may have appeared to others as difference was also, for me, a way of maintaining an inner life when I did not feel that I could rely on the family around me to provide the recognition and protection I needed.**

**At eighteen, I left home and lived on the dole in a squat. That is a significant fact in my personal history because it demonstrates the degree of independence I was required to develop at an early age. I was not entering adulthood from a position of equal security or support. I was trying to survive outside the family home, relying on limited resources and my own ability to adapt. I had to work out how to live without the ordinary assurances that a young person might expect from their family.**

**The contrast with my sister, whom I experienced as the golden child, is central to my understanding of the unequal treatment within the family. I cannot imagine that she would ever have been expected to survive or live under the same conditions. In my experience, the expectations, protections and opportunities afforded to us were profoundly different. I was the child who had to find a way through hardship, while I understood my sister to occupy a position within the family that carried a different level of acceptance and security.**

**The significance is not merely that one child had a more comfortable experience than another. It is that unequal treatment can shape a person's understanding of their own worth, their place in the family and what they can expect from other people. When one child experiences neglect, rejection and early independence while another appears protected, the difference can become a defining feature of the family relationship. For me, it contributed to the feeling that I had never been granted the same unquestioned right to belong.**

**I carried that history into adulthood. I continued to seek connection, to offer kindness and to maintain the hope that family belonging might eventually be restored. Yet I also**

**carried the knowledge that I had already survived without the family support that I believed should have been available to me. That contradiction became increasingly important as I tried to understand the later estrangement: I had been required to live independently from a young age, but the loss of family belonging continued to have consequences well into my adult life.**

**Phillip Island: The Day the Extended Family Unexpectedly Appeared**

**One event that has acquired particular significance for me in retrospect occurred when I became engaged to Shane, my much younger fiancé, at Phillip Island. I casually mentioned to Mum that she should come down. What happened next was unusual enough that I have continued to think about it: the entire extended family ended up turning up on that one day, in circumstances that I remember as absurd, unexpected and entirely out of character.**

**There had been no invitation, as I understood it, that would explain why everyone would arrive together in this way. I had casually mentioned to my mother that she should come down, yet the result was that the extended family appeared to gather around an event in my life. The scale and timing of their attendance seemed disproportionate to the casual nature of the invitation. Looking back, I find it difficult to reconcile that gathering with the wider history of exclusion and unequal treatment I experienced.**

**At the time, it might have been interpreted as an expression of family support. The family had appeared, after all, at a significant moment in my life. Yet the event has become more complicated in my memory because it sits against the history of my childhood, the differences in treatment between my sister and me, and the later rupture that culminated in my exclusion from The Family.**

**I have wondered whether their unexpected appearance reflected guilt about the way I had been treated, discomfort about the possibility of losing me, or a desire to demonstrate support in a way that did not require anyone to acknowledge the underlying problems. I have even wondered, looking back, whether the gathering represented an unusual attempt to compensate for the treatment I had experienced or whether it had some connection to decisions about my eventual exclusion.**

**I cannot establish from the gathering alone what motivated each person to attend, and I do not want to present speculation about their private intentions as a proven fact. What I can say is that the event remains striking because of the contrast it presents: a family that could appear together at a significant moment in my life, yet whose relationships with me later became defined by estrangement, silence and exclusion.**

**That contradiction is what gives Phillip Island its significance in my personal narrative. The gathering appeared, on the surface, to show family unity and support. In retrospect, it raises questions for me about what that unity meant, what was understood but never said, and how a family could collectively appear to acknowledge my life at one moment while I later experienced such a profound loss of belonging.**

**Perhaps the most painful part is that I had no way of knowing, at the time, how I would eventually interpret that day. I was living through the event as it happened, without the benefit of the later experiences that would cause me to reconsider the history of my family relationships. Only after the later estrangement could I look back and see the gathering as part of a larger and unresolved story.**

**The Significance of the Difference**

**The childhood neglect, the early necessity of surviving independently, the refuge I found in imagination and art, the contrast with my sister, and the unexpected gathering at Phillip Island are not separate anecdotes to me. Together, they form part of the history through which I have tried to understand my relationship with The Family.**

**I experienced myself as the child who had to become independent, the person who learned to survive through imagination, and the adult who continued to seek belonging despite a long history of feeling treated differently. My sister's position as the golden child became, in my understanding, a symbol of the unequal protections and expectations within the family. Phillip Island became a reminder of the contradictions: the capacity to assemble as a family when the occasion called for it, alongside the later absence of the recognition and support that I needed.**

**These experiences do not, by themselves, establish a coordinated plan or prove what any family member privately intended. Their significance lies in the pattern I experienced and in the questions that pattern raises. They help explain why the later exclusion was not experienced as an isolated disagreement, but as the culmination of a lifetime in which I had struggled to secure the same belonging, care and recognition that I believed should have been mine from the beginning.**

**I had already learned to survive alone long before I was formally exiled from The Family. I had learned to live with limited resources, to use my imagination to create an inner world, and to turn experience into art and expression. What I could not have known at eighteen was how much those early experiences would later matter when I tried to understand the full course of my life.**

**I now see that the child who had to survive through imagination became the adult who**

**would use writing, research and documentary preservation to reconstruct his own history. My art and my archive are connected by that same need: to give form to experiences that might otherwise remain invisible, to preserve what I remember and what I have documented, and to create a record that can be examined beyond the confines of the family narrative.**

**I was not simply different. I was a child who experienced being treated differently, a young person who had to find his own way into adulthood, and an adult who continued to seek an explanation for the distance between the family belonging I had hoped for and the exclusion I ultimately experienced.**

**That is why these memories matter. They are part of the foundation of my testimony, and part of the explanation for why I have continued to tell my story, preserve the evidence and insist that my life be understood in its full historical context.**

**The Child Who Had to Survive Alone: Unequal Treatment, Imagination, Art, Family Belonging and the Contradictions of Recognition**
**Childhood, Imagination and the Need to Create**

**I have spent much of my life trying to understand why I was treated so differently within my own family, and why childhood so often felt like a place where I had to survive emotionally on my own. I experienced what I understood to be abuse, neglect, unequal treatment and the kind of family dynamics that left me feeling that I could not depend on the people who should have provided me with safety, acceptance and protection. I came to understand my sister as the golden child, someone who appeared to be afforded a different set of expectations and a different experience of family life from the one I was expected to endure.**

**When a child cannot reliably find safety, understanding or recognition in the world around him, he may begin to construct an inner world in which he can survive. For me, imagination became a refuge. Art, drawing and personal expression gave me somewhere to put the things I could not adequately explain, somewhere to explore my thoughts, and somewhere to develop an identity that was not entirely dependent on how other people treated me. Working alone, drawing alone and developing my own artistic language became significant parts of my life. They were not simply hobbies or ways to pass the time. They were ways of making sense of experience, expressing what was difficult to communicate and maintaining a sense of self when I felt that the people around me did not recognise or understand me.**

**I believe the significance of that creative life deserves to be understood in its own right. I was not merely withdrawing into imagination; I was producing things, developing**

**ideas, making images and finding ways to express myself. The work represented effort, persistence, observation and a capacity to create something out of experiences that had often left me feeling isolated. Art gave form to an inner life that might otherwise have remained unseen. It allowed me to make something that belonged to me, even when I felt that other parts of my life were being defined by circumstances and expectations imposed by others.**

**I left home at eighteen and lived on the dole in a squat. That was the reality of the independence I had to establish for myself. It was not an abstract adventure or a romantic idea of youthful freedom. It was a difficult way to begin adult life, with limited money and without the kind of security that many young people reasonably expect from their families. The contrast I have long perceived between my circumstances and those of my sister is central to my understanding of the unequal treatment I experienced. I could not see my sister being expected to survive under the same conditions, with the same degree of independence, uncertainty and deprivation. I experienced myself as the one who had to find a way through, while another member of the family appeared to receive a different measure of care and consideration.**

**The Contradiction Between Artistic Achievement and Material Support**

**There was another contradiction that followed me into adulthood. No matter how much work I put into my art, how much I advertised it, how many websites I designed to promote it, or how much effort I invested in presenting my work to the public, the recognition and practical support I received did not seem commensurate with what I had achieved.**

**I worked alone. I created the art, developed the ideas, organised the practical details and tried to find an audience. I invested my own time, labour, imagination and limited resources in the hope that the work might find a place in the world. I did not have a substantial financial safety net behind me. Every expense mattered. The materials, the production of the work, the framing, the preparation for exhibitions and the other costs associated with presenting art publicly could consume money that I could ill afford to lose.**

**Yet when I did secure exhibitions, I often experienced the arrangements as exploitative or financially disadvantageous. I would carry the cost of creating the work and framing it, along with the time and labour required to prepare everything for display, while the financial return to me was minimal. The result could be an expensive exercise in which I had taken the financial risk, supplied the work and borne the costs, only to make very little money from the entire undertaking.**

**For someone living with so little money, this was not a minor inconvenience. It was a serious financial burden. Creating and exhibiting art can be expensive even for people with secure incomes, professional networks and the resources to absorb a loss. For me, each exhibition required a substantial commitment of scarce funds. I was trying to establish myself through creative work while simultaneously living with the limitations of poverty and the consequences of having to make my own way.**

**The contradiction was that I could put extraordinary effort into making the work visible, design websites to promote it, advertise exhibitions and take the practical steps necessary to bring the art before an audience, yet the economic structure surrounding the exhibitions could leave me carrying most of the cost. I experienced the situation as one in which my labour and creativity were available for public display, but the financial and practical risks remained mine.**

**I cannot claim that every disappointing commercial outcome was deliberately arranged against me. An exhibition that fails to generate sales is not, by itself, proof of exploitation or coordinated conduct. Nevertheless, the pattern as I experienced it raises a legitimate question about the relationship between artistic recognition and material support. Praise is easy to offer. Genuine support requires something more tangible: a fair arrangement, an honest understanding of the work, a willingness to engage with it seriously and, where appropriate, a willingness to purchase it or help sustain the person who created it.**

**When the Entire Family Arrived at Once**

**What made some of these exhibitions particularly difficult to understand was the behaviour of people from my own family and social world. On a couple of occasions, the entire extended family seemed to arrive together, along with Jodie's friends and many of the regulars who had once inhabited our shared lives in Healesville. They appeared all at once, in a collective gathering that struck me as unusual given the broader history of my relationships with them.**

**They would approach me with a peculiar politeness. They would say things such as, "It's so good," and "You're so talented," offering praise that, in the circumstances, felt strangely exaggerated, uncomfortable and difficult for me to reconcile with the relationships I knew. I could not readily understand why people who had witnessed so much of my life, including the family tensions and the difficulties I had experienced, would suddenly appear together at an art exhibition and express admiration in this way.**

**I did not experience their praise as necessarily reflecting a deep understanding of the work. I felt that many of them did not understand what my art was about, what I was**

**trying to express, or what had gone into producing it. Their words seemed disconnected from the substance of the work and from the broader circumstances of my life. It was as though the social performance of turning up, saying something complimentary and acknowledging my talent could stand in for a more difficult engagement with who I was, what I had experienced and what the art was attempting to communicate.**

**The spectacle struck me as absurd. In my own blunt vernacular, it felt like a dog's bollocks sticking out: something so conspicuous and incongruous that it was difficult for me not to notice it. Why would so many people from a family and social circle in which I had experienced exclusion and unequal treatment suddenly assemble in this coordinated-looking way to praise my work? What did their presence mean? Was it ordinary social curiosity, an attempt to be supportive, a way of managing appearances, or something else entirely?**

**I cannot establish their collective motive merely from the fact that they attended. Their presence does not prove that they had coordinated their behaviour, nor does it establish that their praise was insincere. But I can describe the effect it had on me. The gathering felt incongruous with the history I remembered, and the contrast between their enthusiastic words and the absence of meaningful support left me questioning what kind of recognition I was actually receiving.**

**That question became more pronounced because many of those who attended appeared to be financially comfortable or wealthy, while I was struggling to fund the creation and framing of the work. Despite the compliments, none of them, as I recall those occasions, bought anything. I had paid to produce the art, taken the financial risk of exhibiting it and absorbed the costs of making it available to the public. They could offer praise without incurring any comparable cost.**

**I am not suggesting that every person who admires an artist must buy a work, or that attendance at an exhibition creates a financial obligation. The significance, for me, lay in the contrast: a large gathering of people who knew me, many of whom had more financial means than I did, could collectively acknowledge my talent while offering no practical contribution to the person who had worked so hard to make that talent visible. Their words recognised something about my creative ability, but the occasion did not translate into the kind of material support that might have helped me continue.**

**PART 3 OF 3**
**The Child Who Had to Survive Alone: Unequal Treatment, Imagination, Art, Family Belonging and the Contradictions of Recognition**

**Recognition Without Understanding**

**What troubled me was not simply that people praised my art without buying it. It was the wider contradiction between being publicly acknowledged as talented and continuing to feel unsupported in the circumstances of my life. The compliments seemed to recognise one part of me while leaving everything else untouched. People could tell me that I was talented without engaging with the experiences that had shaped me, the difficulties I had overcome, or the financial and emotional realities of trying to sustain a creative life without reliable support.**

**I found myself asking whether recognition had become a substitute for understanding. It is possible to acknowledge someone's achievement without understanding what it cost them to produce it. It is possible to offer encouragement without taking an interest in the conditions under which the person lives. And it is possible for a gathering to look supportive from the outside while leaving the person at its centre feeling just as isolated as before.**

**I cannot know what each person privately thought when they attended those exhibitions. I cannot establish that the compliments were part of a plan, or that anyone's failure to purchase a work was motivated by hostility. I can, however, describe the contradiction as I experienced it: I was being told that I was talented while continuing to struggle financially, carrying the cost of my own work and trying to understand why the people who knew me appeared able to acknowledge my abilities without offering meaningful assistance.**

**That experience brought me back to the unequal treatment I remembered from childhood. I had grown up feeling that my sister and I occupied different positions within the family, with different expectations and different levels of protection. As an adult, I continued to encounter situations in which I could be acknowledged for an achievement without feeling that I was receiving the same degree of care, consideration or practical support that I believed other family members could expect.**

**The parallel is part of my interpretation of my life, not proof that every later event was caused by the same motive. What connects these experiences for me is the feeling of being recognised selectively: my work could be praised, my talent could be acknowledged and my presence could be celebrated on particular occasions, yet the deeper questions about my circumstances and my place within the family remained unresolved.**

**There is a difference between being seen and being understood. There is also a difference between being congratulated and being supported. My experience of these exhibitions made those distinctions painfully clear.**

**The Phillip Island Engagement and the Contradictions of Family Belonging**

**Another event that remains significant in my understanding of family relationships occurred when I became engaged to Shane, my much younger fiancé, at Phillip Island. I casually mentioned to Mum that she should come down. What followed was extraordinary to me: the entire extended family turned up on that one day.**

**I remember the gathering as unexpected, disproportionate to the casual nature of my invitation and difficult to reconcile with the broader history of my family relationships. I had not understood that my passing suggestion to my mother would result in the extended family assembling around this particular event in my life. The scale of their attendance made the occasion stand out in my memory.**

**On the surface, the gathering could be interpreted as an expression of family unity. My engagement was an important personal event, and the family had appeared to acknowledge it. Yet that apparent unity sat uneasily alongside my recollections of childhood, my understanding of the different treatment afforded to my sister and me, and the subsequent estrangement that ultimately left me feeling excluded from The Family.**

**I have wondered whether the gathering reflected guilt about the way I had been treated, concern about the possibility of losing me, or a desire to demonstrate family support without confronting the underlying difficulties in our relationships. I have also wondered whether the event represented an attempt to compensate for earlier treatment or whether it had some connection to decisions and attitudes that only became apparent to me in retrospect.**

**Those are questions arising from my recollection and interpretation of the event. The gathering itself does not establish what motivated each person to attend, and I cannot present my suspicions about private intentions as proven facts. What I can say is that the event has remained striking because of the contrast it represents: a family capable of assembling around a significant moment in my life, yet a family relationship that later became defined, from my perspective, by silence, estrangement and exclusion.**

**The contradiction is difficult to ignore. If the family could come together in that way, what did that gathering mean? Was it an expression of genuine affection, a moment of ordinary family solidarity, an attempt to repair something that had never been openly discussed, or simply an event whose significance I have reconsidered in light of what happened later? I cannot provide a definitive answer on the basis of the gathering alone.**

**What makes the memory so important to me is that I did not know, while the event was happening, how I would eventually interpret it. At the time, I was living through an occasion in my life. Only after later experiences of estrangement could I look back and consider how that moment fitted into the larger history of my family relationships.**

**The gathering at Phillip Island and the unexpected attendance at my art exhibitions share a feature in my recollection. Both involved people appearing collectively at moments when I was visible in some particular way. Both could be interpreted as expressions of interest or support. Yet neither, in my experience, resolved the deeper questions about belonging, understanding and the unequal treatment that had shaped my life.**

**I do not claim that the events were necessarily coordinated or that they had a common hidden purpose. Their significance is that they left me confronting a recurring contradiction: people could appear together to acknowledge a particular event or achievement, while the more enduring questions about my welfare, my circumstances and my relationships remained unanswered.**

**The Significance of the Pattern**

**When I look back across my life, I see a connection between the childhood in which I felt treated differently, the early independence I was forced to develop, the refuge I found in imagination and art, the exhibitions at which my work was praised but not purchased, and the unexpected family gathering at Phillip Island.**

**These are not merely separate anecdotes to me. Together, they form part of the history through which I have tried to understand my relationship with The Family and the consequences of the exclusion I ultimately experienced.**

**I understood my sister to occupy the position of the golden child, with a level of protection and acceptance that I did not experience in the same way. I was the child who had to find a way through hardship, who developed an inner world to survive emotionally, and who left home at eighteen to live on the dole in a squat. I became accustomed to relying on my own imagination, initiative and determination because I did not feel that I could depend consistently on the family environment to provide the support I needed.**

**That early experience shaped my relationship with independence. I learned to survive with limited resources and to create something from what was available to me. I pursued art, developed my own ideas and tried to establish a life through creative expression. I continued to seek recognition and connection even when I felt that the**

**circumstances of my life made those things difficult to secure.**

**Yet the capacity to survive independently did not eliminate my need for belonging. Being able to live alone, create art and find ways to support myself did not mean that family exclusion ceased to matter. I could survive without the family support I believed should have been available to me, but that did not make the loss of family relationships inconsequential.**

**This is one of the central contradictions of my experience. I had to become independent early, but I continued to hope that I might be understood and accepted. I developed ways to live without the protection I believed I needed, but I did not stop wanting the ordinary recognition and care that family relationships are supposed to provide. I could build an inner world through imagination and create work that reflected my experience, but I could not make the unresolved questions about my family disappear simply by becoming self-reliant.**

**The exhibitions brought another dimension to this contradiction. People could acknowledge my talent, attend my exhibitions and compliment my work without necessarily understanding the circumstances in which I had produced it. Their attendance did not establish their motives, and their failure to purchase my work did not prove hostility. Nevertheless, I experienced a painful distance between public praise and meaningful support. The recognition I received on particular occasions did not necessarily translate into a deeper understanding of my life.**

**Phillip Island remains significant for a similar reason. The family's unexpected attendance could be interpreted as support, but the later estrangement made it difficult for me to understand that moment in isolation. I continue to wonder what the gathering meant and how it should be understood alongside the wider history of our relationships. I recognise that I cannot establish the private intentions of the people who attended simply by examining my own recollection of their presence.**

**These experiences do not, by themselves, establish a coordinated plan or prove what any family member privately intended. Their significance lies in the pattern I experienced, the contradictions I remember and the questions that remain unresolved. They help explain why the later exclusion was not experienced by me as an isolated disagreement. It felt connected to a much longer history in which I had struggled to secure the same belonging, care and recognition that I believed should have been mine from the beginning.**

**I had already learned to survive alone long before I was formally exiled from The Family. I had learned to live with limited resources, to use imagination to create an inner world,**

**and to turn experience into art and expression. What I could not have known at eighteen was how much those early experiences would later matter when I tried to understand the full course of my life.**

**I now see that the child who had to survive through imagination became the adult who would use writing, research and documentary preservation to reconstruct his own history. My art and my archive are connected by that same need: to give form to experiences that might otherwise remain invisible, to preserve what I remember and what I have documented, and to create a record that can be examined beyond the confines of the family narrative.**

**For me, the act of documenting my life is not simply an exercise in revisiting old grievances. It is an attempt to establish a coherent account of experiences that I have struggled to reconcile, to distinguish what I remember from what I can substantiate, and to leave a record that others can examine independently. I want the context of my life to be understood rather than reduced to a single incident, a label or someone else's interpretation of who I am.**

**I was not simply different. I was a child who experienced being treated differently, a young person who had to find his own way into adulthood, and an adult who continued to seek an explanation for the distance between the family belonging I had hoped for and the exclusion I ultimately experienced.**

**The imagination that helped me survive became a means of expression. Art became a way of giving form to my inner life. Writing and documentary preservation became ways of recording my experiences and attempting to understand their place in the wider history of my life. Each has allowed me to retain a voice and to create a record that does not depend entirely on whether other people acknowledge or agree with my interpretation.**

**I cannot change the childhood I experienced, recover the years spent trying to understand the differences in treatment, or compel anyone to provide an explanation for the estrangement. What I can do is describe my experience honestly, preserve the work I have created and make a clear distinction between the events I remember, the records I hold and the conclusions I have drawn from them.**

**That is why these memories matter. They are part of the foundation of my testimony, and part of the explanation for why I have continued to tell my story, preserve the evidence and insist that my life be understood in its full historical context.**

**My art was part of how I survived. My writing became part of how I understood that**

**survival. My archive is an extension of the same effort: to preserve a record of my life, to give shape to what I have experienced and to leave something that can be examined beyond the limits of my own recollection.**

**The child who had to survive alone is still part of the person I am. But I am also the adult who has continued to create, document, question and seek understanding. My history cannot be reduced to the circumstances in which I struggled, the relationships I lost or the judgments other people may have made about me. It includes the work I produced, the life I built, the evidence I preserved and the determination with which I have continued to tell my story.**

**I have tried to make something meaningful from the experiences I could not control. I have used imagination where I lacked security, art where I needed expression, and documentation where I needed a lasting record. I cannot dictate how others will interpret that record, but I can ensure that my account exists and that the distinctions between memory, evidence, interpretation and unresolved questions remain visible.**

**That is the significance of this history. It is the story of a child who learned to survive through imagination, an adult who continued to seek belonging, and a person who turned to art and documentary preservation to give form to experiences that might otherwise remain unseen.**

**I remain entitled to tell my story in my own voice. I remain entitled to preserve the record of my life. And I remain entitled to ask that my experiences be considered in their full context, rather than dismissed or understood through a single, incomplete account.**

**I would make this a devastating closing chapter by focusing on the contrast between the family's public reputation and your account of what you experienced privately, the years you say you spent seeking their love, and the moral responsibility you believe they must confront. The strongest conclusion does not need to establish unproven motives as facts; it lets your testimony, chronology and preserved records speak.**

**The Enemy Within: The Price of Their Perfect Facade**

**A Final Reckoning with Family Exile, Betrayal and the Cost of Integrity**

**There is a particular cruelty in being betrayed by the people from whom you spent your entire life seeking love. The people whose acceptance you wanted most are the people whose conduct you have come to question most deeply. The people who could have offered protection, understanding and compassion instead became, in your experience, part of the circumstances from which you needed protection. And the people who knew**

**your vulnerabilities, your history and your suffering were also the people best placed to understand what their actions, their silences and their refusals to intervene could mean for your life.**

**For years, I returned to my family with the hope that something might change. I believed that if I remained patient, if I continued to love them, if I explained myself more clearly, if I survived another crisis and tried again, there might eventually be a moment when they would understand me. I kept returning because I wanted what so many people take for granted: to be accepted by my own family, to be loved without having to prove my worth, and to be allowed to exist without being treated as a problem that needed to be contained.**

**I now look back upon that hope with profound sadness. I believe I spent years trying to secure acceptance from people who, in my experience, repeatedly failed to provide the understanding, protection and support I needed. I kept searching for evidence that the relationships could be repaired, while the history I was accumulating increasingly demanded that I examine whether those relationships were safe, reciprocal or capable of giving me the acceptance I had continued to seek.**

**The tragedy was not that I wanted too much. I wanted to belong. I wanted my family to recognise my humanity. I wanted the people closest to me to care whether I was safe, whether I had somewhere to live, whether I could survive financially, and whether the repeated crises in my life were leaving me increasingly vulnerable. I wanted them to see a person, not a diagnosis, a burden, a source of embarrassment or a convenient explanation for difficulties they did not wish to confront.**

**Instead, I experienced a pattern of exclusion, unequal treatment and unresolved questions that I can no longer separate from the broader history of my life. I believe the family relationships that should have offered me a foundation of security became part of the circumstances in which I experienced isolation, financial hardship and the loss of belonging.**

**The Golden Child and the One Who Was Expected to Survive**

**The difference between my sister's position in the family and mine has always mattered to my understanding of what happened. I experienced her as the golden child: the daughter whose relationship with Mum and Dad appeared to provide her with a level of acceptance, security and privilege that I did not experience in the same way.**

**At eighteen, I left home and lived on the dole in a squat. That is not a theoretical difference in our childhood experiences. It is a concrete part of my history. I was**

**required to find my own way into adulthood under conditions that I cannot imagine being considered acceptable for my sister. I learned to survive with limited resources, to construct an inner world through imagination, and to use art and creativity to preserve a sense of identity when I did not feel understood by the people around me.**

**I experienced my sister as someone who remained aligned with the family expectations and values that I increasingly questioned. I perceived her as preoccupied with money, appearance and privilege, and as someone who mirrored Mum and Dad rather than challenging the differences in how we were treated. Those are my recollections and interpretations of our relationship. What matters most to my testimony is the contrast I experienced between the protections I believed she received and the independence, insecurity and hardship I was expected to navigate.**

**I do not believe that a family demonstrates its morality merely by maintaining a respectable appearance, travelling together, securing comfortable housing or presenting an image of unity to the outside world. The deeper measure is how its members treat one another when there is no audience, when someone is vulnerable, when providing help is inconvenient, and when acknowledging the truth would require uncomfortable questions about the conduct of people they love.**

**A family can appear successful while a member of that family is struggling to survive. It can maintain its public reputation while private relationships deteriorate. It can celebrate achievements, attend gatherings and offer compliments while leaving unresolved the experiences of the person who has been excluded. Public respectability does not, by itself, establish private compassion.**

**That is the contradiction I ask my family to confront. I am not asking readers to condemn them merely because I have written an account of my suffering. I am asking that the appearance of family respectability not be treated as an answer to the documented history I have preserved or as a reason to dismiss the questions I have raised.**

**If my family believes my account is inaccurate, there is an opportunity to address the specific events, correspondence and decisions involved. If they believe they acted with compassion, they can explain what they did, when they did it, and how those actions were intended to protect me. If they believe they had no responsibility for particular outcomes, they can explain the basis of that position.**

**What cannot resolve the matter is silence alone.**

**The Questions of Illness, Financial Advantage and Responsibility**

**One of the most serious questions in my testimony concerns the relationship between my illness, my financial circumstances and the conduct of people whom I believe benefited while I was struggling.**

**I have questioned whether my illness and vulnerability became circumstances from which other people obtained financial or practical advantage, while those same circumstances were left unresolved or used to explain away the difficulties I experienced. I have also questioned whether people who appeared as rescuers at particular moments were willing to confront the wider conditions that contributed to my repeated crises.**

**I believe my family, my former fiancé and other people in my life must be examined in the context of the events I have documented, including the decisions and relationships that affected my security, independence and wellbeing. I have raised serious concerns about whether my illness was treated as an explanation for my circumstances while the conduct of others, and the possibility that they benefited from those circumstances, escaped equivalent scrutiny.**

**These are serious questions, and they deserve to be assessed through evidence rather than assumptions. A financial benefit, an illness, a relationship breakdown or a person's presence during a crisis does not, in isolation, prove deliberate exploitation or the deliberate creation of illness. The significance lies in the complete chronology: who knew what, who made which decisions, what records were created, what financial consequences followed, and whether the evidence supports a conclusion that anyone acted improperly.**

**That is why I have continued to preserve documents and reconstruct the sequence of events. I want the circumstances of my life examined as a whole, not reduced to an isolated diagnosis or a convenient account in which responsibility disappears behind the language of illness, administration or family concern.**

**I also question the repeated appearance of people in the role of saviours after crises in which I felt abandoned or unsupported. I remember periods when I needed practical protection and sustained assistance, not simply intervention after circumstances had deteriorated. The question I want answered is not whether someone occasionally helped me. It is whether the assistance was consistent with the person's knowledge, capacity and responsibilities, and whether the broader conduct of those involved helped resolve my vulnerability or left me exposed to it again.**

**If people benefited from circumstances that harmed me, that should be examined. If my**

**vulnerability was exploited, the evidence should be assessed. If the records do not support my interpretation in a particular instance, that distinction should also be made clear. I want the truth established through a serious examination of the material, not through a contest in which the person with the least power is automatically expected to accept the most convenient explanation offered by everyone else.**

**The Former Fiancé, the Questions of Intelligence and the Institutions That Failed Me**

**My account also raises serious questions about my former fiancé, the relationship in which I experienced harm, and my concerns about possible connections to intelligence-related activity. I have described my former fiancé as connected to ASIO, and I have questioned whether other people or institutions knew more about the circumstances of that relationship than they acknowledged.**

**I cannot establish an intelligence affiliation, an organised conspiracy or a coordinated plan simply by stating that I believe one existed. Those questions require corroboration, reliable records and careful examination. But neither should the existence of unresolved questions be used as a reason to dismiss the experiences I have documented or the harm I report having suffered.**

**I have also raised concerns about homophobia, police conduct and institutional responses to my circumstances. As a gay and disabled man, I believe my identity and vulnerability must be considered when examining how I was treated, how my reports were received and whether the responses I encountered were consistent with the obligations those institutions were supposed to uphold.**

**I have questioned whether homophobic attitudes, conflicts of interest, institutional defensiveness or failures of accountability contributed to the treatment I experienced. These concerns should be examined against the available records, including the correspondence, decisions and other primary-source material I have preserved.**

**The same standard must apply to everyone involved. Neither a uniform, a professional title, a government position, a family relationship nor a public reputation should place a person's conduct beyond examination. Equally, a serious accusation must be assessed on the evidence rather than accepted or rejected solely because of the identity of the person making it.**

**I have spent years trying to make my experiences intelligible to institutions that I believed should have been capable of examining them. I have preserved their correspondence and their decisions because I want the reasoning behind those decisions to be available for scrutiny. I want to know what was considered, what was**

**disregarded, which obligations were engaged and whether the responses I received were adequate in the circumstances.**

**My insistence on these questions is not a demand that anyone accept every conclusion I have reached without examination. It is a demand that the underlying material be taken seriously.**

**The More Than Fourteen Hospitalisations and the Human Cost of Abandonment**

**I have described being incarcerated or hospitalised more than fourteen times across three states. Those experiences form part of the history of my life, and I cannot understand them without considering the wider circumstances in which they occurred.**

**For me, the repeated crises were not simply disconnected medical events. They were periods in which I experienced profound vulnerability, loss of control and uncertainty about my future. I believe the responses to those crises must be considered alongside the support available to me, the conduct of the people around me, the decisions made by institutions and the consequences of those decisions for my ability to live independently.**

**I have questioned whether the people closest to me adequately recognised the seriousness of my circumstances, whether they took reasonable steps to protect me, and whether their conduct contributed to the conditions in which my life became increasingly difficult to sustain. I have also questioned why periods of crisis could be followed by a return to apparent normality for others while the consequences remained with me.**

**A person can leave an institution without having recovered their housing, financial security, relationships, reputation or sense of safety. A discharge does not resolve every cause of a crisis. Nor does a diagnosis answer every question about the circumstances in which a person became vulnerable.**

**My concern is that the repeated crises in my life were too often treated as individual events, rather than as part of a wider history requiring sustained attention. I wanted people to ask what had happened before, what support had failed, what risks remained, and what needed to change to prevent further harm.**

**Instead, I experienced the consequences of each crisis accumulating over time. The loss of security made the next difficulty harder to withstand. Isolation reduced the number of people to whom I could turn. Financial hardship narrowed my choices. The absence of reliable support left me increasingly dependent on my own capacity to survive.**

**I want those consequences recognised as part of the human history behind the documents. The records matter, but they are not abstractions. Each decision, referral, refusal, delay or omission occurred in the context of a human life.**

**Nana, Family Separation and the Inheritance Questions**

**My memories of Nana have become another important part of my attempt to understand the family history. I have come to question whether the treatment I experienced reflected a broader pattern of family relationships in which people who were strong, independent or difficult to control became isolated from the support and companionship they needed.**

**In retrospect, I have wondered whether Nana experienced a similar kind of exclusion. I have questioned whether she was separated from people and relationships that mattered to her, whether her circumstances were managed in ways that served other people's interests, and whether decisions concerning her estate and inheritance were handled in accordance with her wishes.**

**I have raised concerns about my father's sister, Aunty Bev, and Ian, whom I understood to be a lawyer, including questions about their roles, their access to Nana and the possible financial consequences of decisions made around her life and death. I have also questioned whether an inheritance that I believed should have been available was withheld or otherwise dealt with in a manner inconsistent with Nana's wishes.**

**These are matters that require evidence of the relevant relationships, financial arrangements, estate documents and decisions. I cannot establish financial abuse, improper influence or entitlement merely from the fact that people were involved in Nana's affairs or that I experienced the outcome as unjust. But I can record the questions I have carried and identify the material needed to assess them.**

**What makes these questions so painful is my recollection of the difference between the way Nana was treated in life and the praise that could be offered after her death. I remember being asked to deliver her eulogy, and I remember the praise associated with my contribution to her life. That recognition meant something to me because my relationship with Nana mattered.**

**Yet the praise also sharpened a contradiction I have struggled to understand. If my contribution to Nana's life was valued, why did I so often feel excluded or unsupported within the wider family? If the family could recognise my love for her at the time of her death, why was it so difficult for me to feel that my own life and suffering received**

**comparable consideration?**

**I have wondered whether Nana and I shared experiences of being misunderstood, marginalised or excluded. I do not claim that our circumstances were identical. I recognise that her life and my life must be understood on their own evidence. But I cannot ignore the possibility that examining her history might illuminate questions about family relationships, money, control and belonging that have also shaped my own.**

**I also remember the circumstances in which other family members travelled to Europe for an extended holiday while I remained at home with my fiancé, whom I experienced as abusive and exploitative. The contrast between their travel and my circumstances remains painful to me. I felt isolated and exposed while others appeared able to enjoy comfort and opportunity.**

**I cannot infer from the holiday alone that anyone intended to abandon or endanger me. But the event forms part of the context in which I experienced a profound imbalance between the freedom and security available to other people and the difficulties I was trying to survive.**

**I want the questions surrounding Nana's care, relationships and estate to be examined fairly. I also want her life to be remembered as more than an inheritance dispute or a source of conflict. She was a person whose relationships mattered, whose wishes deserved respect and whose history should not be reduced to the interests of those who survived her.**

**The Shame of a Perfect Public Facade**

**My family may disagree with my interpretation of our history. They may believe that their conduct was justified, that they did what they could, or that my recollections fail to capture their perspective. They are entitled to respond to the specific matters I have raised.**

**But they cannot resolve the moral questions simply by maintaining the appearance of a successful family.**

**The public image of a family is not the same thing as the private truth of its relationships. Travel, comfortable homes, professional achievements, social standing and outward respectability cannot establish that every family member has been treated fairly. Nor can they erase the consequences experienced by someone who believes that they were excluded, neglected or left to survive without adequate support.**

**If my family believes its public reputation accurately represents the way it has treated me, then it should be able to account for the history I have described. It should be able to explain the difference in the circumstances in which my sister and I entered adulthood. It should be able to address the periods in which I was homeless or living in poverty, the repeated crises I experienced, the relationships I have described as harmful, and the questions I have raised about Nana's circumstances.**

**It should be able to distinguish what it knew from what it did not know, what it could reasonably have done from what was beyond its control, and what it regrets from what it continues to defend.**

**I am not demanding that anyone perform guilt for the benefit of my audience. I am demanding that the appearance of virtue not be treated as a substitute for accountability.**

**If my family has acted honourably, a careful examination of the facts should help demonstrate that. If it has made mistakes, an honest response would acknowledge them. If its members believe my account is mistaken, they can identify the particular claims they dispute and explain why. None of those responses requires humiliation, retaliation or public abuse.**

**What I cannot accept is the idea that the person who has experienced the consequences should remain silent merely to protect the comfort, status or reputation of those who do not share them.**

**The shame I describe is not a verdict I can impose on another person's conscience. It is the moral discomfort that may arise when people are asked to compare their public values with their private conduct. If there is a discrepancy, it is for those involved to confront it honestly.**

**I have had to confront the discrepancy between the family I hoped I had and the relationships I experienced. My family must decide whether it is willing to confront the questions my testimony raises.**

**The Price of Integrity**

**There is a price to refusing to remain silent when silence would be more convenient. I have experienced that price in relationships, financial circumstances, social belonging and the struggle to establish a stable life. I have also experienced the cost of continuing to hope that people might change, even when my history gave me reason to question whether they would.**

**I once believed that love, patience and forgiveness might eventually lead to understanding. I believed that if I continued to explain myself, my family might recognise the person behind the conflict and the circumstances behind the distress. I believed that a future might exist in which we could acknowledge what had happened without requiring me to deny my own experience.**

**I have had to reconsider that hope. Forgiveness, in my faith, does not require me to pretend that harm did not occur. Love does not require me to remain in relationships that I experience as damaging. And the desire for reconciliation does not require me to surrender my right to describe the past or preserve the evidence relevant to it.**

**I can leave ultimate judgment to God while continuing to ask human beings to account for their decisions. I can refuse revenge while refusing silence. I can recognise that I cannot know every person's private motive while still insisting that actions, omissions and documented decisions be examined for their consequences.**

**I do not need to destroy another person's life to tell the truth about my own. I do not need to invent certainty where the evidence leaves questions unresolved. I do not need to imitate the conduct I believe harmed me in order to insist that my experience matters.**

**My integrity depends on maintaining those distinctions. I want the record to be strong enough to withstand scrutiny, including scrutiny of my own conclusions. I want the documents to be available, the chronology to be coherent and the difference between evidence and interpretation to remain clear.**

**That is the opposite of erasure. It is the decision to leave a record that can be read, questioned and assessed independently.**

**They Expected My Story to End**

**For a long time, I felt as though other people had come to regard my circumstances as permanent: as though poverty, illness, isolation and crisis would define the boundaries of my life indefinitely. I felt that my possibilities were being measured by the most difficult periods I had endured, rather than by my capacity to recover, create, learn and continue.**

**I cannot know what every person expected of my future. But I know how it felt to be living through repeated hardship without reliable support, and I know how easily a person's suffering can become the only story others are willing to hear about them.**

**I am still here.**

**I continued to write. I continued to create. I continued to preserve documents, reconstruct timelines and attempt to understand the history of my life. I continued to seek a way to make my experiences intelligible beyond the immediate relationships and institutions through which they had unfolded.**

**My archive is part of that effort. It is not a substitute for independent verification, and it does not make every interpretation automatically correct. Its purpose is to preserve material that can be examined, compared and assessed. It gives readers the opportunity to look beyond my conclusions and consider the underlying records for themselves.**

**My survival does not prove every allegation I have made. But neither does the existence of disputed interpretations erase the fact that I have a history, that I have documented experiences and that I am entitled to ask serious questions about the treatment I received.**

**The record should be judged by what it contains. The claims should be assessed against the evidence. The unanswered questions should remain visible until they can be answered. And the person whose life is represented in those documents should not disappear behind the language used to describe him.**

**The Final Word**

**To those whom I believe contributed to my suffering, my message is simple: you do not have to agree with my interpretation of every event, but you should not assume that your silence will determine how my life is remembered.**

**To the institutions whose records I have preserved, I ask that your decisions be examined against the responsibilities you were required to uphold. To the professionals who dealt with me, I ask that your actions and reasoning be considered in their proper context. To my former fiancé and the people involved in the relationships I have described, I ask that the evidence be allowed to speak without intimidation, distortion or convenient omissions.**

**And to my blood family, I ask something more personal.**

**Look beyond the public image. Look beyond the family story that has allowed everyone to continue with their lives. Look at the child who left home at eighteen and had to survive on his own. Look at the adult who continued to seek acceptance, even after**

**repeated disappointment. Look at the person who wanted to be loved by his family and who kept returning because he believed that, one day, they might understand him.**

**Consider what it means when a person spends years trying to earn a place that they believed should have been theirs without conditions. Consider what it means when someone continues to hope for reconciliation while feeling that their experiences are being dismissed. Consider what it means when a person has to build an archive of his own life because he fears that his account will otherwise be ignored, misrepresented or lost.**

**You may remember the past differently. You may reject my interpretation. But if you believe that I am wrong, answer the specific questions. Address the evidence. Explain the decisions. Do not confuse the preservation of a respectable appearance with the resolution of the underlying history.**

**I cannot compel you to love me. I cannot compel you to understand me. I cannot make you acknowledge what I believe you have failed to acknowledge. And I cannot recover the years I spent hoping that our relationships would become what I needed them to be.**

**What I can do is stop making my existence dependent on your approval.**

**I can stop waiting for permission to tell my story. I can stop confusing the possibility of reconciliation with an obligation to remain silent. I can stop treating the absence of an explanation as proof that I should abandon the questions.**

**If there is shame to confront, each person must confront it through their own conscience and their own conduct. If there are mistakes to acknowledge, those involved must decide whether they are prepared to acknowledge them. If there is evidence of wrongdoing, it should be examined through appropriate and independent processes. If my conclusions are mistaken in particular respects, the record should permit that to be demonstrated as well.**

**I leave ultimate judgment to God. I do not seek revenge. I seek truth, accountability, dignity and the freedom to live without having to prove my humanity to the people who were supposed to recognise it.**

**My family may continue with its life. Its members may travel, maintain their homes, enjoy their relationships and preserve whatever public image they consider important. None of those things is, by itself, proof of wrongdoing. But neither is any of it an answer to the questions I have raised about my own life.**

**I am no longer willing to measure my worth by whether I am included in their world.**

**I was a child who wanted to be loved. I became an adult who learned to survive without the support I believed I should have received. I became an artist who used imagination to give expression to an inner life that had too often gone unrecognised. I became a writer who tried to make sense of experience. And I became the keeper of a documentary record because I wanted my history to remain available for examination.**

**That is my response to exclusion: not to disappear, but to preserve my voice.**

**That is my response to betrayal as I experienced it: not to seek revenge, but to insist that the record remain.**

**That is my response to the loss of belonging: to build a life whose meaning does not depend on whether my family welcomes me back.**

**I gave my family years of patience, love and opportunities for reconciliation because I believed those relationships could change. I cannot know what the future holds, but I no longer need to sacrifice my dignity in the hope that someone else will finally recognise it.**

**The child who had to survive alone has become the adult who can tell his own story. The person who once searched for acceptance now understands that belonging cannot be secured by repeatedly abandoning himself. The man who once hoped that silence would eventually be replaced by understanding has chosen to preserve a record that can be examined beyond the boundaries of the family.**

**My testimony is not a demand that the world accept every conclusion without question. It is a demand that my life, my records and my experiences be considered seriously, honestly and in context.**

**I am still here. I am still creating. I am still documenting. I am still bearing witness.**

**My faith remains. My conscience matters. My life has value beyond the judgments of my family, the decisions of institutions or the public image of people who may never agree with my account.**

**I will not claim to know what every person intended. I will not pretend that every unresolved question has already been answered. But I will not allow uncertainty about another person's motives to erase the experiences I remember or the records I have preserved.**

**The truth deserves examination. The vulnerable deserve dignity. Family relationships deserve honesty. Public institutions deserve scrutiny. And no person's humanity should depend on whether those with greater power find it convenient to recognise them.**

**I wanted to be accepted and loved. I wanted my family to understand me. I wanted to believe that compassion would eventually overcome the differences that had separated us.**

**I cannot make those hopes come true by myself.**

**What I can do is tell the truth as I understand it, preserve the evidence, acknowledge the limits of what I can prove, and continue to live according to the faith and integrity that have sustained me.**

**They may have their own account of who I am. I have mine, supported by the records I have preserved and open to independent examination.**

**I am not asking for permission to exist.**

**I am not asking for permission to remember.**

**I am not asking for permission to tell my story.**

**I am still here.**

**My testimony remains.**

**My faith remains.**

**And I leave revenge to God.**

**Praise Jesus.**